

ACEY

Written by
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INT. ORION'S ROOM - NIGHT

BLACK.

Keys to a computer click off. They're rapid fire, then we hear the slamming defeat of the delete key. They sound off again. The delete key returns. A very irritated sigh erupts from Orion. 22, short cropped hair, a resting bitch face.

IN THE DARKNESS, A BRIGHT BLUE LIGHT APPEARS.

As it dims, we focus in on Orion's phone screen. We land on his Instagram feed full of other students out partying or attending festivals. Most of them are straight passing.

OPHELIA (V.O.)

How goes it?

ORION (V.O.)

I'm screwed.

OPHELIA (V.O.)

No, no. It's not that type of night. I will not be performing those services.

ORION (V.O.)

Ophelia, I'm serious. I have nothing to write about, and this fucking deadline is creeping up. Who assigns a capstone level film to a sophomore?

OPHELIA (V.O.)

"A simple reminder that you chose this major."

ORION (V.O.)

"It's imperative that you make art."

OPHELIA (V.O.)

"It's imperative that you make art."

ORION (V.O.)

"Before the art makes you." I just can't think of a truth that's worth telling.

OPHELIA (V.O.)

Well... think harder.

A long moment of nothing. Next, we land on Orion's profile page. We see:

His username— orions.belt

His profile picture with his partner, Acey. 21, flowing brown hair, tan, fit like a Greek god, complete with a silly, infectious smile.

Photos of his life. His time at school. Photos with Acey. Some to be considered "queer looking" posts. One of him in a crop top. Obviously the ones with Acey are a bit fruity. There's a scandalous Halloween party amongst many others.

Orion slowly scrolls, analyzing each photo and caption. He changes one specifically that says *wish you were queer*, to *wish you were here*. He sighs.

As we continue scrolling: Orion pauses on a photo to scrutinize it. Something shifts.

ORION (V.O.)

Do you think straight men hate me?

OPHELIA (V.O.)

I don't think you want me to answer that.

ORION (V.O.)

Is it a bad answer?

OPHELIA (V.O.)

It's a complicated one.

ORION (V.O.)

Okay...

(then)

Then is my feed too gay? Like overtly queer. I like being queer, I just don't want to be in people's face about it because I don't like it when people are in my face about it.

OPHELIA (V.O.)

(chewing and not paying any attention)

No, not one bit.

ORION (V.O.)

Ok good. I want to respect people. I'm trying to give straight but curious vibes.

OPHELIA (V.O.)

For who?

WE COME UP FOR AIR.

Orion comes into focus in the frame. He lays on the floor with his feet up on the bed. He's in his favorite band's shirt, jeans, and socks. Behind him sits his computer with a blank document, save for the words. *INT.* Ophelia lays on the bed barefoot. 24, short cropped hair, has one of Orion's school sweaters pulled over. She eats gummy bears out of a bag like they're made of air.

ORION

(thinks)

People in general. I don't want anyone thinking—

OPHELIA

That your partner happens to be a boy.

ORION

Well, I mean—

Ophelia lowers imaginary sunglasses and gives *are you being for real right now eyes*.

OPHELIA

You are dating a boy and you like boys, but you don't want people to know either of those things.

ORION

I don't want to throw it in their face.

OPHELIA

Posting about your partner isn't throwing anything in anyone's face. If straight people can force feed hundreds of years of love stories to society, I think it's acceptable for you to share your missing half with your insignificant sliver of the world. Who cares?

ORION

You were referring to when Zeus split souls.

OPHELIA

(with a gummy poised over her mouth)

You're correct. I was.

ORION
(in disbelief)
And you think men used to be sewn
together with men.

OPHELIA
I don't think. I know.

Ophelia stands as if to break into a presentation. She does exactly this. Out of what seems to be thin air, a white screen appears. She snaps and a blue projector screen comes to life on the screen. Two images appear: Two men are sewn together in one of the images, and two women in the other. She grabs a ruler and slaps the first image. A steady indie rock song comes to life behind her. She clips each word with distaste.

OPHELIA (CONT'D)
MEN. Filthy, rude, arrogant,
obnoxious, selfish, mislead and
misleading, antagonistic—

ORION
Alright. Alright.

OPHELIA
And they are consistently?
(waits for the invisible
audience)
Wrong. Even when they are right.
Worse yet, they naturally find
companionship with one another.
It's the blind leading the fucking
blind.

ORION
And if you don't follow, you get
cast out. Out of the womb I come.
Go ahead and fix me up a baby
sweater. Stitch a bright red F on
my shirt for Fa—

OPHELIA
(slapping the ruler and
with wide eyes)
Fatherless. Who's to say they
weren't once sewn together? Who's
to say their love doesn't extend
past a type that is brotherly in
nature? Who's to challenge the
possibility that our souls once had
divergent choices? Who is to deny
them that choice now? They are.
Them. The naysayers. The blind.

ORION
The hecklers.

OPHELIA
The bastards.

ORION
Well, they aren't all bad.

OPHELIA
Don't go weak on me Orion. You
can't succumb to their cheap charm.
They mask it over with the same
intoxicating cologne. All of them.

ORION
I believe I own that cologne.

OPHELIA
Of course you do! To fit in. To be
one of them. *You don't have to be
one of them.* They're the ones who
say you and Acey shouldn't be happy
together- that it's impossible.
That queerness coincides with
loneliness, depression, and
addiction.

ORION
I just don't see how that's true.

OPHELIA
Because of the mass amounts of sad,
alcoholic, men who hit 30 without a
partner. 30 is dead in gay years.

ORION
I think that's a gross
overstatement.

OPHELIA
I think I have a works cited page
at the end of this slideshow in
which I cited multiple primary
sources.

ORION
Alright, you win.

OPHELIA
Now, Orion, why the sudden fixation
with straight men?

ORION

It's not a fixation. It's a general concern.

OPHELIA

(with genuine concern)

I'm concerned about the fact that you're concerned. Are you planning on courting one? Having sex with one? Falling in love with one?

ORION

Ophelia, God no.

Orion interlocks his fingers and places them on top of his chest.

ORION (CONT'D)

I've just never had a great relationship with them. You know me, I'm great with words, but when I come face to face with a guy, my words come out silly, sloppy, and stupid. My brain works backward and my tongue trips over itself.

Ophelia has gone from presenter to therapist. She sits cross-legged with a notepad next to Orion and writes fervently.

OPHELIA

I see. A classic case of cotton mouth mixed with a severe case of spoonerisms.

ORION

Spooner-what?

OPHELIA

(very seriously)

Orion.

ORION

(looking up at her)

Ophelia.

OPHELIA

Are you... embarrassed?

ORION

Of?

OPHELIA
(quietly, then rising with
intensity)
Being around straight men. Being
queer. Your lack of straight
heritage. Acey. Yourself.

ORION
I am not embarrassed about Ace.

OPHELIA
(looking over her notes)
And yet—

Orion slams a hand on her notepad.

ORION
(in a serious slow manner)
I, am not, embarrassed.
(beat)
I'm not. I just struggle with these
things. I always have.

OPHELIA
Why?

ORION
I don't know.

Ophelia readjusts her notepad and writes down something. She
circles it several times. She holds it up to Orion's face,
but we don't see the words.

OPHELIA
This is what you write your film
about.

ORION
(scoffing)
You're serious?

OPHELIA
I am.

ORION
Ophelia.

Ophelia slaps him on the head with the notepad.

OPHELIA
Damnit Orion! Just try it. If it
doesn't work, throw it out.

ORION
(holding his head)
I don't write like that. I never
have.

OPHELIA
Exactly. You'll discover the
possible behind the impossible.
"Before the art makes you Orion."

A blue bright light emits from Orion's phone. It rings. Acey's photo pops up. Orion answers it and immediately the ringing transitions into a shell shock ring. It rises in intensity as a look of devastation spreads like cancer across Orion's face. The ringing is now UNBEARABLE AND WE...

CUT TO BLACK.

The ringing slowly fades.

INT. ORION'S HOUSE - MIDNIGHT

CU: on a Keurig coffee pod. The lid slams. We hear buttons click and the machine comes to life. We pan down and watch the coffee pour quickly into a cup.

A SERIES OF SHOTS:

FALLING CREAMER, SUGAR, A STIRRING SPOON.

Orion lifts the cup and travels. We slowly follow behind him and pan across the oven timer that reads 12:11. We swing around and are met with a very dark room. Blackness has been invited in from the night. A window sits open in the distance. The sounds of the night are the backdrop of this moment.

From what we can see, the room is an absolute mess. Acey's clothes, mostly shirts, are everywhere. Paper balls litter the floor (story ideas). Blankets cover the space. Coffee cups line any open counter real estate.

Orion settles onto a couch and pulls a blanket across his lap. He reaches for an open laptop and sits in stillness. He looks to a framed photo of him and Acey standing together. He studies it. He flips it over, and on the back is a letter from Acey, which he reads. He folds it, tapes it to the back of the frame, and sets the picture face down on the couch.

He turns to his laptop and his fingers fly. He starts writing a screenplay and doesn't stop. We pan back and stand watching him hunched over his laptop. We stay like this for a while.

Finally he stops, leans back against the seat, rereads what he's written, then looks up directly at us. He pulls out his phone and calls Ophelia.

ORION

Hi. Yes, I'm ok. I'm fine. Will you shut up, please? I have **something**.

(quiet as if someone is listening in)

I do. I just wrote it. Right now.

Yes, it's good. Of course, it is.

We can both be the judge.

The sound of the phone hanging up sounds off. Orion slams his laptop shut and we...

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. ORION'S HOUSE (BACKYARD) - MORNING

WE FLY DOWN AND SMACK

A table as a freshly printed script.

CU ON THE PAGE:

In the middle, *THESIS*. Underneath and underlined is Written by Orion Rolatier.

WIDE PAN OUT.

Empty coffee mugs come into view. The same one that lined Orion's room. They've been washed. Orion comes around and places spoons in each of them. He then meticulously places a single pack of sugar next to each of them. He's very particular about this. He sets out two pots of creamer. He considers their placement, switches them, and then switches them back. Lastly, he comes by with a fresh pot of coffee and commits the perfect pour for each cup. He goes around and wipes each mug and the table with a rag, cleaning up any coffee stains.

Orion sits in the center of the table and nervously rubs his thighs. He straightens the scripts next to him. He notices one of the script packets is stapled wrong and has displaced the pages by the slightest inches. He tries to pick at the staples to fix the pages, but the back door to the house opens. Orion stands quickly and puts the script down. Roman, Silas, and Ophelia step into his universe.

Roman, 21. Half asleep but god-like. Strikingly exactly similar to Ace (the same actor might even play the two with slight changes in makeup and wardrobe).